

Attachment 1 – Solicitation Terms and Conditions

Description

This is a combined synopsis/solicitation for commercial items prepared in accordance with the format in FAR Part 12. This announcement constitutes the only solicitation; offers are being requested, and a separate written solicitation will not be issued.

Solicitation number 12639526Q0018 is issued as a Request for Quotation (RFQ) for the USDA, AMS, Cotton Program, which requires the removal of the existing bale press and the delivery and installation of a new full eject bale press and automated conveyor system with a scissor lift-tilt table to be delivered and installed at the Memphis Classing Office. The USDA also requests quotes for disassembling and removing the existing bale press at the Memphis Classing Office located at the following address: **Cotton and Tobacco Program Cotton Division, 3275 Appling Rd Memphis, TN 38133.**

This acquisition is set-aside for small business concerns. This solicitation incorporates provisions and clauses by reference. The full text of provisions and clauses may be accessed electronically at www.acquisition.gov.

The applicable North American Industry Classification Standard Code is 333111. The small business size standard is 1250 employees. This acquisition is a Total Small Business Set-Aside. All responsible sources may submit a quotation which will be considered by the agency.

See “Attachment 1 - Solicitation Terms and Conditions” for applicable clauses, instructions, and evaluation criteria.

Statement of Requirement

USDA, AMS, Cotton Program, which requires the removal of the existing bale press and the delivery and installation of a new full eject bale press and automated conveyor system with a scissor lift-tilt table to be delivered and installed at the Memphis Classing Office. The USDA also requests quotes for disassembling and removing the existing bale press at the Memphis Classing Office located at the following address: **Cotton and Tobacco Program Cotton Division, 3275 Appling Rd Memphis, TN 38133.** The Contractor must furnish all labor, materials, equipment, parts, permits, insurance, supervision and transportation necessary to complete the removal of the existing system and the delivery and installation of the entirety of the new system specified within the Statement of Work (SOW) and provide on-going maintenance service necessary to maintain the equipment in good operating condition, including routine/preventive maintenance, scheduled inspections. These systems must be maintained at optimum efficiency in accordance with manufacturers' recommendations.

See Attachment 2 - Specifications for a list of all requirements.

Technical Data - Technical data and supporting documentation associated with this solicitation are available through the following sources:

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1. Solicitation Attachments & Exhibits:

The following documents are included as attachments to this solicitation and can be accessed via the “Attachments/Links” section of the posting.

- Attachment 1 - Solicitation Terms and Conditions
- Attachment 2 – Specifications
- Attachment 3 – Vendor Quotation Form Solicitation 12639526Q0018
- Attachment 4 - Vendor Experience and Past Performance Sheet Solicitation 12639526Q0018
- Attachment 5 - Provision FAR 52.225-18 Place of Manufacture
- Exhibit 1 – Photographs
- Exhibit 2 – Drawings
- Exhibit 3 - Questions and Answers Previous Solicitation

Attachment 1 – Solicitation Terms and Conditions

Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) and United States Department of Aquiculture Acquisition Regulation (AGAR) Clauses and Provisions

The clauses and provisions contained herein are applicable to any order awarded as a result of this solicitation. The terms and conditions set forth herein supersede all other terms and conditions. Acceptance of the order in accordance with (IAW) FAR 12.201-1(b)(2) constitutes acceptance of all terms and conditions contained herein.

As part of the Revolutionary FAR Overhaul (RFO), system updates may lag policy updates. The System for Award Management (SAM) may continue to require entities to complete representations based on provisions that are not included in this solicitation. Contracting officers will rely on representations from offers based on provisions in the solicitation. Entities are not required to, nor are they able to, update their entity registration to remove these representations in SAM.

52.252-2 Clauses Incorporated by Reference

Feb 1998

This solicitation incorporates one or more clauses by reference, with the same force and effect as if they were given in full text. Upon request, the Contracting Officer will make their full text available. Also the full text of the clause may be accessed electronically at Internet address <https://www.acquisition.gov/far-overhaul/far-part-deviation-guide/far-overhaul-part-52>

- 52.212-4 Terms and Conditions—Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) of 52.212-4
- 52.203-17 Contractor Employee Whistleblower Rights (Nov 2023)
- 52.203-19 Prohibition on Requiring Certain Internal Confidentiality Agreements or Statements (Jan 2017)
- 52.222-50 Combating Trafficking in Persons (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) of 52.222-50
- 52.226-8 Encouraging Contractor Policies to Ban Text Messaging While Driving (May 2024)
- 52.232-40 Providing Accelerated Payments to Small Business Subcontractors (Mar 2023)
- 52.233-3 Protest After Award (Sep 2025)
- 52.233-4 Applicable Law for Breach of Contract Claim (Sep 2025)
- 52.240-91 Security Prohibitions and Exclusions (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) of 52.240-91
- 52.244-6 Subcontracts for Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2025)

The following clauses are applicable if checked:

- ☒ 52.203-6 Restrictions on Subcontractor Sales to the Government (Jun 2020) with Alternate I (Nov 2021) of 52.203-6
- ☐ 52.203-13 Contractor Code of Business Ethics and Conduct (Nov 2021)
- ☐ 52.204-9 Personal Identity Verification of Contractor Personnel Jan 2011
- ☒ 52.204-13 System for Award Management—Maintenance (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.204-91 Contractor identification (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.209-6 Protecting the Government’s Interest When Subcontracting with Contractors Debarred, Suspended, or Proposed for Debarment (Sep 2025)
- ☐ 52.209-9 Updates of Publicly Available Information Regarding Responsibility

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Matters (Sep 2025)

- ☒ 52.209-10 Prohibition on Contracting with Inverted Domestic Corporations (Sep 2025)
- ☐ 52.219-4 Notice of Price Evaluation Preference for HUBZone Small Business Concerns (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.219-6 Notice of Total Small Business Aside (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Mar 2020).
- ☐ 52.219-8 Utilization of Small Business Concerns (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.219-9 Small Business Subcontracting Plan (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate III (Nov 2025) of 52.219-9.
 - ☐ Alternate IV (Nov 2025) of 52.219-9
- ☐ 52.219-14 Limitations on Subcontracting (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.219-16 Liquidated Damages—Subcontracting Plan(Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.219-33 Nonmanufacturer Rule (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.222-3 Convict Labor (June 2003)
- ☐ 52.222-19 Child Labor—Cooperation with Authorities and Remedies (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.222-35 Equal Opportunity for Veterans (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Jul 2014) of 52.222-35
- ☒ 52.222-36 Equal Opportunity for Workers with Disabilities (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Jul 2014) of 52.222-36
- ☒ 52.222-37 Employment Reports on Veterans (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.222-40 Notification of Employee Rights Under the National Labor Relations Act (Dec 2010)
- ☒ 52.222-54 Employment Eligibility Verification (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.222-62 Paid Sick Leave Under Executive Order 13706 (Jan 2022)
- ☐ 52.223-9 Estimate of Percentage of Recovered Material Content for EPA-Designated Items (May 2008)
 - ☐ Alternate I (May 2008) of 52.223-9
- ☒ 52.223-11 Ozone-Depleting Substances and High Global Warming Potential Hydrofluorocarbons (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.223-12 Maintenance, Service, Repair, or Disposal of Refrigeration Equipment and Air Conditioners (Nov 2025)
- ☒ 52.223-23 Sustainable Products and Services
- ☐ 52.224-3 Privacy Training (Jan 2017)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Jan 2017) of 52.224-3
- ☒ 52.225-1 Buy American-Supplies (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Oct 2022) of 52.225-1
- ☐ 52.225-3 Buy American--Free Trade Agreements--Israeli Trade Act (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate II (Nov 2025) of 52.225-3.
 - ☐ Alternate III (Nov 2025) of 52.225-3.
 - ☐ Alternate IV (Oct 2022) of 52.225-3
- ☐ 52.225-5 Trade Agreements (Nov 2023)
- ☐ 52.225-19 Contractor Personnel in a Designated Operational Area or Supporting a Diplomatic or Consular Mission outside the United States (May 2020)

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- ☐ 52.225-26 Contractors Performing Private Security Functions Outside the United States (Oct 2016)
- ☐ 52.226-4 Notice of Disaster or Emergency Area Set-Aside (Nov 2007)
- ☐ 52.226-5 Restrictions on Subcontracting Outside Disaster or Emergency Area (Aug 2025)
- ☐ 52.229-12 Tax on Certain Foreign Procurements
- ☐ 52.232-29 Terms for Financing of Purchases of Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2021)
- ☐ 52.232-30 Installment Payments for Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2021)
- ☒ 52.232-33 Payment by Electronic Funds Transfer— System for Award Management (Oct 2018)
- ☐ 52.232-34 Payment by Electronic Funds Transfer—Other Than System for Award Management (Jul 2013)
- ☐ 52.232-36 Payment by Third Party (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.240-92 Security Requirements (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.240-93 Basic Safeguarding of Covered Contractor Information Systems (No 2025)
- ☐ 52.247-64 Preference for Privately Owned U.S.-Flag Commercial Vessels (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Apr 2023) of 52.247-64.
 - ☐ Alternate II (Nov 2021) of 52.247-64

Other Applicable Clauses

52.247-34 F.O.B. Destination (Jan 1991)

AGAR Clauses

The following Agriculture Acquisition Regulation (AGAR) clauses are provided in full-text and will apply to this contract:

452.203-71 Anti-Discrimination and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Compliance (Dec 2025)

(a) By entering into this contract, the Contractor certifies that:

1. It is compliant with all applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws and the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution, and it will remain compliant for the duration of the contract.
2. Neither it nor any subcontractor or teaming partner operates or funds any program, policy, or initiative that promotes DEI in a manner that violates any applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws, including but not limited to Title VI and VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, or the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution, and the Contractor and any subcontractor or teaming partner will not do so for the duration of the contract.

(b) If the Contractor participates in, facilitates, or funds programs that implicate Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 or Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, as amended, including but not

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limited to grants to or for schools, colleges, universities, 4-H programs, non-governmental organization (NGO) programs, sports programs, and education-related grants to prisons or other detention facilities, the Contractor certifies that it will remain compliant with those laws, including the requirements set forth in Executive Order 14168, Defending Women from Gender Ideology Extremism and Restoring Biological Truth to the Federal Government, and Executive Order 14173, Ending Illegal Discrimination and Restoring Merit-Based Opportunity.

(c) The Contractor affirms that the above requirements are conditions of payment that go to the essence of the contract and are therefore material terms of the contract. Payments under the contract are predicated on compliance with the above requirements, and therefore the Contractor is not eligible for funding under the contract or to retain any funding under the contract absent compliance with the above requirements.

(d) This certification reflects a change in the Government's position regarding the materiality of the foregoing requirements and therefore any prior payment of similar claims does not reflect the materiality of the foregoing requirements to this contract.

(e) Submission of a knowing false statement relating to Contractor's compliance with the above requirements and/or eligibility for the contract may subject the Contractor to liability under the False Claims Act, 31 U.S.C. § 3729, and/or criminal liability, including under 18 U.S.C. §§ 287 and 1001.

(f) The Contractor must include the provisions of this clause in all subcontract solicitations.

(g) Failure on the part of the Contractor or its subcontractors to comply with the terms of this clause may be grounds for the Contracting Officer to terminate this contract for default.

(End of Clause)

452.204–70 Modification for Contract Closeout (Nov 2025)

(a) If unliquidated funds in the amount of \$1000 or less remain on the contract, the Contracting Officer (Contracting Officer) shall issue a unilateral modification for deobligation. The contractor will receive a copy of the modification but will not be required to provide a signature. The Contracting Officer shall immediately proceed with contract closeout upon completion of the period of performance, receipt and acceptance of supplies or services, and final payment.

(b) Upon contract closeout for contracts utilizing SAP: if unliquidated funds of more than \$1000 remain on the contract, the Contracting Officer shall issue a bilateral modification for deobligation. The contractor will receive a copy of the modification and will be required to provide a signature. (The Contracting Officer may also request a "Contractor Release of Claims" be completed by the contractor, although not required for contracts and orders using SAP.) If the bilateral modification and Release of Claims are not returned to the Contracting Officer within 60 days, the Contracting Officer shall release the modification as unilateral and proceed with contract closeout upon completion of the period of performance, receipt and acceptance of supplies or services, and final payment.

(c) Upon contract closeout for contracts utilizing anything other than cost reimbursement, if unliquidated funds of more than \$1000 remain on the contract, the Contracting Officer shall issue a bilateral modification for deobligation. The contractor will receive a copy of the modification and a "Contractor Release of Claims" and will be required to provide a signature on both forms. If the

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bilateral modification and Release of Claims are not returned to the Contracting Officer within 120 days, the Contracting Officer shall release the modification as unilateral and proceed with contract closeout upon completion of the period of performance, receipt and acceptance of supplies or services, and final payment.

(End of Clause)

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Solicitation Information

Award Type

It is anticipated that a firm fixed-price contract containing a six (6) month delivery date from the date of award will be awarded as a result of this synopsis/solicitation.

The Government intends to make one award from this solicitation. Therefore, to be considered responsive, contractors must submit pricing for all items.

Evaluation and Basis for Award

Evaluation Criteria

The provision at FAR 52.212-2, Evaluation—Commercial Products and Commercial Services is not applicable to this solicitation. In lieu of this provision, quotes will be evaluated in accordance with FAR 12.203 based on the criteria listed below. Award will be made to the offeror with the highest technically rated quotation with fair and reasonable pricing and acceptable or neutral past performance.

Technical Approach: The technical approach will evaluate the ability of the offeror to provide a sound, compliant approach offeror's ability to provide a sound and compliant approach that meets all requirements and shows a thorough understanding of them. It is the contractor's responsibility to ensure their quotation clearly demonstrates their capability to meet these requirements. All offerors must provide the following minimum information and documentation with their quotations to be considered responsive and have their offers evaluated:

- A **Technical Approach Narrative** must be submitted with quotations and must address the entire system and scope of the services required and must demonstrate a clear understanding of the requirements of this Statement of Work. The Technical Approach Narrative submitted by the Vendor **must not exceed ten (10) pages in length**, including pictures and tables. The Technical Approach Narrative submitted by the Vendor with their quotation must include the following:

A milestone chart of the removal of the existing bale press system and the delivery and installation of the new bale press system. **Existing system must be removed and new system must be installed and ready for operation no later than six (6) months after the date of award.**

All drawings, operations and technical manuals that detail the operation and components and demonstrate that the **bale press** meets the requirements of all of the items detailed within Section .

All drawings, operations and technical manuals that detail the operation and components and demonstrate that the **scissor lift-tilt** meets the requirements of all of the items detailed within Section C.4 SPECIFICATIONS.

All drawings, operations and technical manuals that detail the operation and components and demonstrate that the **conveyor system** meets the requirements of all of the items detailed within Section C.4 SPECIFICATIONS.

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Detail how the tasks listed in Section C.5 TASKS of the Statement of Work will be performed.

Detail how the training described in Section C.6 TRAINING of the Statement of Work will be provided.

Detail the warranty for the entire system (ref. Section C.7 WARRANTY)

Price:

NOTE: Vendors must utilize Attachment 3 - Vendor Quotation Form Solicitation 12639526Q0018 to submit their price quotation in response to this solicitation.

The resulting award will be a Firm Fixed-Price contract containing a six (6) month delivery date from the date of award.

The offeror's quotation will be evaluated in accordance with FAR 12.204, to determine if it is fair and reasonable.

Past Performance:

NOTE: Vendors must utilize Attachment 4 - Vendor Experience and Past Performance Sheet Solicitation 12639526Q0018 to submit their past performance references within their quotation in response to this solicitation; Attachment 4 must include a minimum of two (2) but no more than five (5) references for experience with projects of the same or similar service and magnitude. Each project must have been performed within the past five (5) years from the date of this solicitation. Vendors must complete the "Customer Identification" section within the attachment for each project referenced.

The Government may utilize any references provided by the Contractor, along with information available from past contracts/orders with the USDA and any information found using sources such as Federal Government sources or the Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) to determine if the Contractor has acceptable or neutral Past Performance. Past Performance will be evaluated using the following rating system:

- Acceptable: The contractor shows a demonstrated ability to meet contract requirements in prior or current contracts, including quality of work, timeliness, cost control, business relations, and adherence to contract terms.
- Neutral: Offeror does not have a past performance record.
- Unacceptable: The contractor has a documented history of failing to meet contract requirements, including poor quality, missed deadlines, cost overruns, lack of responsiveness, or unethical behavior.

Evaluation Method:

All quotations will be evaluated to identify the offeror presenting the most technically advantageous solution based on the stated evaluation criteria. Once the highest technically rated offeror is identified, their price will be evaluated to determine whether it is fair and reasonable. Past performance will also be assessed to ensure it is acceptable or neutral.

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Award will be made to the offeror whose proposal is determined to be the highest technically rated, provided that:

- The proposed price is fair and reasonable, and
- Past performance is assessed as acceptable or neutral.

Award will not necessarily be made to the lowest-priced offeror. Tradeoffs will not be conducted.

Delivery Information

F.o.b. destination is requested as the F.O.B. point for all deliverables.

All offers will be considered F.O.B. Destination unless F.O.B. origin is specified AND estimated shipping costs are included.

The USDA requires delivery of all items by six (6) months after the date of award. It is anticipated that the contract will be awarded in February 2026. Early deliveries will be accepted.

Shipping Instructions:

Items shall be shipped to the following address:

USDA, AMS, C&T Program Memphis Classing Office located at 3275 Appling Rd Memphis, TN 38133

Qualification Requirements

Offerors, or the product or service, are not required to meet a qualification requirement to be eligible for award.

52.252-1 Solicitation Provisions Incorporated by Reference Feb 1998

This solicitation incorporates one or more solicitation provisions by reference, with the same force and effect as if they were given in full text. Upon request, the Contracting Officer will make their full text available. The offeror is cautioned that the listed provisions may include blocks that must be completed by the offeror and submitted with its quotation or offer. In lieu of submitting the full text of those provisions, the offeror may identify the provision by paragraph identifier and provide the appropriate information with its quotation or offer. Also, the full text of a solicitation provision may be accessed electronically at this/these address(es): <https://www.acquisition.gov/far-overhaul/far-part-deviation-guide/far-overhaul-part-52>

52.212-1 Instructions to Offerors - Commercial Products and Commercial Services (Nov 2025)

FAR 52.212-1 is amended as follows:

Period for acceptance of offers.

Vendors must agree to hold the prices in its quote firm for **90 calendar days** from the closing date of the solicitation within SAM.gov.

Questions

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Questions must be submitted via email to Matthew.Phillips3@usda.gov and are due no later than January 20, 2026, at 12:00 PM Central Time. This will ensure enough time to respond before the solicitation period ends. Please include the solicitation name and number as the subject line of the email.

- 52.203-18 Prohibition on Contracting with Entities that Require Certain Internal Confidentiality Agreements or Statements-Representation (Jan 2017)
- 52.240-90 Security Prohibitions and Exclusions Representations and Certifications (Nov 2025)

The following provisions are applicable if checked:

- ☒ 52.203-11 Certification and Disclosure Regarding Payments to Influence Certain Federal Transactions (Sep 2024)
- ☒ 52.204-7 System for Award Management—Registration (Nov 2025)
 - ☐ Alternate I (Nov 2025) to 52.204-7
- ☐ 52.204-90 Offeror Identification (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.207-6 Solicitation of Offers from Small Business Concerns and Small Business Teaming Arrangements or Joint Ventures (Multiple-Award Contracts) (Aug 2024)
- ☐ 52.209-12 Certification Regarding Tax Matters (Oct 2025)
- ☐ 52.219-2 Equal Low Bids (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.222-18 Certification Regarding Knowledge of Child Labor for Listed End Products (Feb 2021)
- ☐ 52.222-48 Exemption from Application of the Service Contract Labor Standards for Maintenance, Calibration, or Repair of Certain Equipment—Certification (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.222-52 Exemption from Application of the Service Contract Labor Standards for Certain Services—Certification (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.222-56 Certification Regarding Trafficking in Persons Compliance Plan (Oct 2020)
- ☐ 52.223-4 Recovered Material Certification (May 2008)
- ☒ 52.225-2 Buy American Certificate (Oct 2022)
- ☐ 52.225-4 Buy American-Free Trade Agreements-Israeli Trade Act Certificate (Nov 2025)
- ☐ 52.225-6 Trade Agreements-Certificate (Feb 2021)
- ☐ 52.226-3 Disaster or Emergency Area Representation (Nov 2007)
- ☐ 52.229-11 Tax on Certain Foreign Procurements—Notice and Representation (Jul 2025)

Other Applicable FAR Provisions

- 52.225-18 Place of Manufacture (Aug 2018)
- 52.237-1 Site Visit (Apr 1984)

52.225-18 Place of Manufacture.

As prescribed in 25.1101 (f), insert the following provision:

Place of Manufacture (Aug 2018)

(a) *Definitions.* As used in this provision—

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Manufactured end product means any end product in product and service codes (PSCs) 1000-9999, except-

- (1) FPSC 5510, Lumber and Related Basic Wood Materials;
- (2) Product or Service Group (PSG) 87, Agricultural Supplies;
- (3) PSG 88, Live Animals;
- (4) PSG 89, Subsistence;
- (5) PSC 9410, Crude Grades of Plant Materials;
- (6) PSC 9430, Miscellaneous Crude Animal Products, Inedible;
- (7) PSC 9440, Miscellaneous Crude Agricultural and Forestry Products;
- (8) PSC 9610, Ores;
- (9) PSC 9620, Minerals, Natural and Synthetic; and
- (10) PSC 9630, Additive Metal Materials.

Place of manufacture means the place where an end product is assembled out of components, or otherwise made or processed from raw materials into the finished product that is to be provided to the Government. If a product is disassembled and reassembled, the place of reassembly is not the place of manufacture.

(b) For statistical purposes only, the offeror shall indicate whether the place of manufacture of the end products it expects to provide in response to this solicitation is predominantly-

(1) ☐ In the United States (Check this box if the total anticipated price of offered end products manufactured in the United States exceeds the total anticipated price of offered end products manufactured outside the United States); or

(2) ☐ Outside the United States.

(End of provision)

AGAR Provisions

452.203-70 Anti-Discrimination and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) Certification (Dec 2025)

(a) By submission of its offer, the offeror certifies that:

3. It is compliant with all applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws and the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution.
4. Neither it nor any proposed subcontractor or teaming partner operates or funds any program, policy, or initiative that promotes DEI in a manner that violates any applicable Federal anti-discrimination laws, including but not limited to Title VI and VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, or the Equal Protection principles of the U.S. Constitution.

(b) If the offeror participates in, facilitates, or funds programs that implicate Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 or Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, as amended, including but not limited to grants to or for schools, colleges, universities, 4-H programs, non-governmental organization (NGO) programs, sports programs, and education-related grants to prisons or other detention facilities, by submission of its offer, the offeror certifies that it is compliant with those laws, including the requirements set forth in Executive Order 14168, Defending Women from Gender Ideology Extremism and Restoring Biological Truth to the Federal Government, and Executive Order 14173, Ending Illegal Discrimination and Restoring Merit-Based Opportunity.

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- (c) The offeror affirms that the above requirements are conditions of payment that go to the essence of the contract and are therefore material terms of the contract. Payments under the contract are predicated on compliance with the above requirements, and therefore the offeror will not be eligible for funding under the contract or to retain any funding under the contract absent compliance with the above requirements.
- (d) This certification reflects a change in the Government's position regarding the materiality of the foregoing requirements and therefore any prior payment of similar claims does not reflect the materiality of the foregoing requirements to this contract.
- (e) Submission of a knowing false statement relating to offeror's compliance with the above requirements and/or eligibility for the contract may subject the offeror to liability under the False Claims Act, 31 U.S.C. § 3729, and/or criminal liability, including under 18 U.S.C. §§ 287 and 1001.
- (f) Failure on the part of the offeror or its subcontractors to comply with the terms of this clause may be grounds for the Contracting Officer to terminate the contract for default.
(End of Provision)

NOTICE FOR FILING AGENCY PROTESTS United States Department of Agriculture (USDA) Ombudsman Program

The USDA is committed to issuing solicitations and awarding contracts in a fair and prompt manner. The Ombudsman Program for Agency Protests (OPAP) was established to address protest issues within the agency, providing an alternative to costly and time-consuming litigation. Operating independently, OPAP offers relief comparable to that granted by the Government Accountability Office (GAO). Interested parties are encouraged to resolve concerns through USDA's internal Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) process before pursuing external forums such as the GAO. Concerns may be addressed informally or through a formal agency protest filed with either the Contracting Officer or the Ombudsman.

Informal Forum with the Ombudsman

1. **Initial Point of Contact:** Interested parties who believe a specific USDA procurement is unfair or otherwise defective should first direct their concerns to the applicable Contracting Officer.
2. **Escalation:** If the Contracting Officer is unable to address their concerns, interested parties are encouraged to contact the USDA Ombudsman for Agency Protests. Under this informal process, the agency is not required to suspend contract award performance. Utilization of the informal forum does not suspend any time requirement for filing a formal protest with the agency or other forums.
3. **Required Information:** To ensure a timely response, interested parties should provide the following information to the Ombudsman: solicitation/contract number, contracting office, Contracting Officer, and solicitation closing date (if applicable).

Formal Agency Protest with the Ombudsman

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1. **Effort to Resolve:** Prior to submitting a formal agency protest, protesters must first use their best efforts to resolve their concerns with the Contracting Officer through open and frank discussions.
2. **Independent Review:** If the protester's concerns remain unresolved, an Independent Review is available by the Ombudsman. The protester may file a formal agency protest with either the Contracting Officer or, alternatively, with the Ombudsman under the OPAP program. Contract awards or performance will be suspended during the protest period unless justified in writing for urgent and compelling reasons or determined in writing to be in the best interest of the Government.
3. **Resolution Timeline:** The agency's goal is to resolve protests within 35 calendar days from the date of filing.
4. **Required Information:** Protests shall include the information set forth in FAR 33.104(a)(3). Failure to submit the required information may result in a delay or dismissal of the protest.
5. **Timeliness:** Protests must be filed within the timeframes specified in FAR 33.104.
6. **Submission:** Formal protests under the OPAP program should be submitted electronically to SPE.inquiry@usda.gov and the Contracting Officer.

Election of Forum. By initiating a protest with the USDA, the protester agrees not to pursue the same matter with the Government Accountability Office (GAO) or any other external forum while the agency protest is pending. If a protest is filed externally, the agency protest will be dismissed.